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(L-R) Stills from
*One Battle After
Another*, *Sinners*,
and Oscar-winning
cinematographer
Autumn Durald
Arkapaw.
(GETTY IMAGES)

Warner Bros. dominated the Academy Awards, but Paramount’s looming acquisition of the studio signals the biggest restructuring of the industry in decades and a battle over the future of Hollywood itself

ELEVEN OSCARS AND A TAKEOVER

Aseem Chhabra

And the winner is Warner Bros. At least where the just-concluded Oscars ceremony is concerned. The studio founded in 1923 by the brothers Harry, Albert, Sam and Jack Warner (yes, there were actually four Warner brothers) had 30 nominations this year, of which it has won 11 Oscars. What happens after this, however, is a concern for some in Hollywood.

Warner Bros. Discovery, the parent company of Warner Bros. studio, has a \$110 billion takeover offer from Paramount and Skydance. The deal has to be approved by the U.S. government authorities since it could create a huge monopoly. Until recently, streaming giant Netflix was in the bid too, for \$82.7 billion.

Many observers feel that the deal could go through later this year since the 2025-established Paramount Skydance CEO David Ellison, 43, and his father Larry, the founder of Oracle Corporation, are close to U.S. President Donald Trump. They are also big financial supporters of Israel.

The drama unfolds

Paramount had some big successes in 2025, from Tom Cruise-led *Mission Impossible: The Final Reckoning*, which grossed \$600 million, to *The Naked Gun* franchise’s latest reboot starring Liam Neeson (\$102 million global box-office), which had a terrific second innings on Amazon Prime. “I think Paramount’s goal is to be the biggest movie studio out there,” says Gitesh Pandya, editor of *BoxOfficeGuru.com*, and a voting member of the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences (AMPAS), which gives out the Academy Awards (Oscars). The other big studios that define the Hollywood terrain are The Walt Disney Company, Universal Pictures, Sony Pictures, and Amazon MGM Studios – a new entity after Jeff Bezos’ Amazon Studios bought MGM in 2022.

“Adding Warner Bros. automatically makes Paramount bigger,” Pandya observes. “Their library is bigger. They have more franchises.” Over the years, Warner Bros. Discovery has acquired many important media assets, including HBO Max, CNN,



Cartoon Network and Turner Classic Movies. Other jewels in its treasury include DC Comics, *Harry Potter*, *F.R.I.E.N.D.S.*, *Game of Thrones*, etc. Paramount Skydance hopes to consolidate all of this wealth under its belt. With the merger, Paramount would be able to add HBO Max’s 132 million worldwide subscribers to the 80 million who are members of the Paramount+ streaming service. This would place Paramount on better competitive ground with Netflix, which has over 325 million global subscribers.

But there are obvious darker aspects of a big merger of this kind. It will definitely result in job losses. “Movie studios, streaming services and television are similar businesses,” Pandya says. “There are a lot of divisions that overlap. Some people will end up getting laid off.” At the Vanity Fair Oscars afterparty, actress-activist Jane Fonda, 88, sported a pin with the text ‘Block the Merger’.

The merger drama started exactly a year ago. Warner Bros. studio heads

‘The Cameraman’ statue outside Warner Bros. Studio, California; and (left) protests in Los Angeles against the Paramount-Warner Bros. merger. (GETTY IMAGES)

Michael De Luca and Pamela Abdy were seemingly in trouble after several box-office failures, including *Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga* (2024), *Joker: Folie à Deux* (2024), and Korean master Bong Joon Ho’s *Mickey 17* (2025). Warner Bros. Discovery CEO David Zaslav was considering replacing De Luca and Abdy.

But spring 2025 overturned De Luca’s and Abdy’s fortunes as they launched one hit after another, starting with *A Minecraft Movie*. Based on the 2011 video game, the film had a built-in audience just like that of *Barbie* (2023), according to Pandya. The film exceeded all expectations, grossing \$961 million worldwide, according to film-revenue-tracking website Box Office Mojo. This was followed by *F1: The Movie* (\$633 million), an Apple TV production distributed by Warner Bros.; *Superman* (\$619 million); *The Conjuring: Last Rites* (\$499 million); *Sinners* (\$370 million) – which became a favourite of audiences and critics; and *The Final Destination Bloodlines* (\$317 million). Even last week’s Oscar Best Picture winner, *One Battle After Another*, a critically acclaimed prestige film, ended up grossing over \$210 million (it’s another matter that owing to its high production costs, it was considered a box-office failure).

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The best writers and storytellers have moved to OTT. There’s a concern in Hollywood that Netflix is the killer of theatrical releases. I don’t think so. Theatrical films have moved towards ‘ride’ movies or Marvel tentpole films where popcorn sales are high

SHEKHAR KAPUR
Filmmaker, actor



These players are distributors of their Hollywood content in India, rather than local producers... they are still going to be releasing their movies theatrically

SIDDHARTH ROY KAPUR
Founder of Roy Kapur Films, former MD of Walt Disney Company India



Adding Warner Bros. automatically makes Paramount bigger. Their library is bigger. They have more franchises

GITESH PANDYA
BoxOfficeGuru.com editor, voting member of the AMPAS



If you had told me this five years ago, I’d have said, ‘Okay, Warner Bros. is in trouble’. But now the studio is doing so good, and they still want to sell off? I don’t get it

ALEX BILLINGTON
FirstShowing.net editor, critic

THE INHERITANCE OF A WIN

As Autumn Arkapaw becomes the first woman cinematographer to pick up an Oscar, Indian female DOPs weigh in on the long road to equality

Udita Jhunjhunwala

When Autumn Durald Arkapaw accepted the Oscar for Best Cinematography at the 2026 Academy Awards, it marked nearly a century of exclusion for women – and women of colour – behind the camera. In India, where cinematography remains one of the most male-dominated departments on film sets, her win resonated deeply. Women DOPs here, from National Award winners Anjali Shukla and Savita Singh, to Priya Seth, Modhura Palit, Kavya Sharma and Preetha Jayaraman, have gradually carved a space in a guarded field.

Even as women DOPs’ work begins to reshape how Indian cinema looks, disparity persists. Talent is often sidelined owing to gender. Four cinematographers weigh in on how visibility, mentorship, and persistence will redesign the future for generations of women wielding the lens. They also share a few trade insights. Seth, for instance, wishes to do away with overly dark visuals and Jayaraman despises the use of zoom lens for action sequences. Both Palit and Sharma are ready to retire the vertical format, “I don’t think it’s cinematic,” says Sharma. As for a shot they will never tire of, Jayaraman mentions the ‘dolly shot’, for Palit, it is the “close-up of faces”, and for Seth, “a well-crafted ‘oner’.”

Then there are the “small-big wins” that only they would notice. For Jayaraman, it is “women feeling safe” on her set.



Kavya Sharma ‘The director didn’t want a female DP’

“Visibility and representation are powerful,” says Sharma (*The Waking of a Nation*, 2025). “When art is created by a diverse group, it reflects a wider range of human experiences.” Jubilant about Arkapaw’s win, she stresses that recognition alone isn’t enough. “I hope it wakes up people in the industry to the gap in representation,” she says.

Sharma’s break came with *Aarya* Season 3 (pictured), after climbing the ranks through second-unit work. She credits director Ram Madhvani for the chance: “Without hesitation, he works with women,” she says, noting that such support reshapes not just hiring but the filmmaking process itself. Madhvani, too,

notes Sharma’s qualities: hunger, focus, and perspectives shaped by lived experience. “The many roles that women play enrich how they see a scene,” he says.

Sharma highlights how having women in the crew changes dynamics on set. “It’s not just about being seen; it’s about the energy, how scenes are imagined, the way characters are treated. That’s important for storytelling.” Access remains the hardest part. Sharma has faced blunt bias: “I’ve been told to my face: the director didn’t want a female DP.” Misconceptions about physicality, she adds, are outdated.

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TRIBUTE [1934-2026]

MISSING THE POET

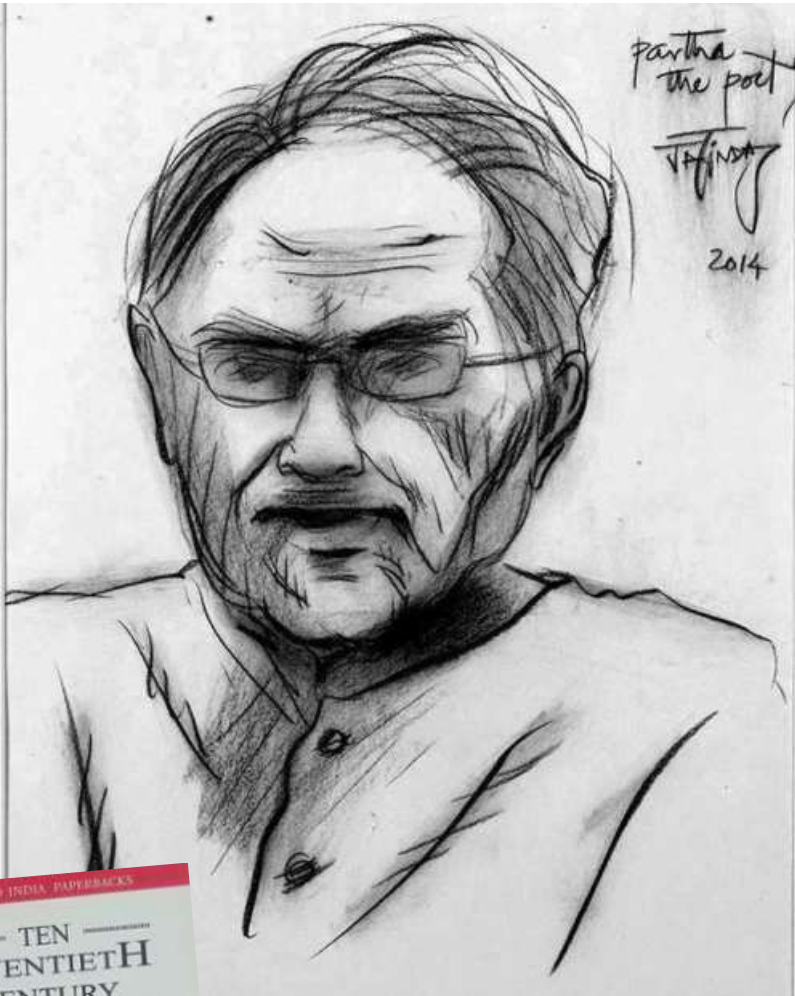
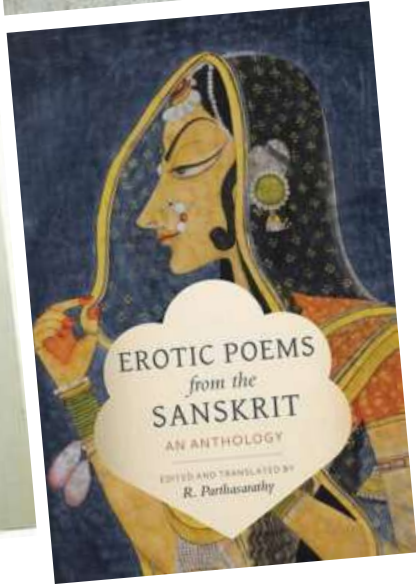
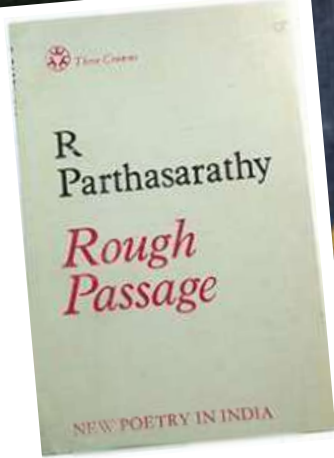
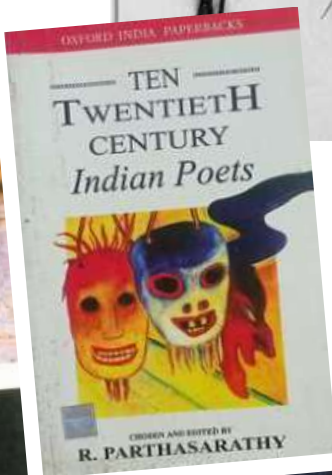
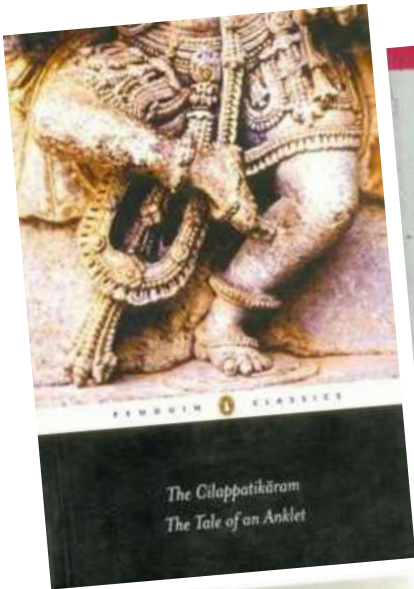
Author Jerry Pinto on how the once-influential voice of R. Parthasarathy in Indian English poetry gradually receded from literary memory

Jerry Pinto

Rajagopal Parthasarathy, who passed away on March 7, in Saratoga Springs, New York, seems to have faded from the poetic consciousness of my generation. While his contemporaries, Adil Jussawalla and Arvind Krishna Mehrotra, for instance, or even A.K. Ramanujan, seem to have kept pace with us, Partha, as his friends called him, was flattened early into literary history.

Perhaps that is because he was swallowed up by the United States, spending many years teaching at Skidmore College. Or it could have been that he simply did not write much.

Parthasarathy's claim to fame rests largely on a single book-length poem, 'Rough Passage' (1977), which seems to have seen two iterations. In the second one, which I have, he writes: "This is a book where all the poems form part of a single poem, as it were... I have at last composed, but perhaps not completed it. In it twenty years of writing has finally settled." We take it as a long poem because the poet says it is one. It is memoir sometimes and post-colonial protest at others, it is travelogue sometimes and diary at others.



His other works include an anthology of Indian poetry in English, *Ten Twentieth Century Indian Poets* (1977); a translation of the Jain prince Ilango Adigal's *Cilappatikaram*, *The Tale of an Ankle*; *An Epic of South India* (1993); and *Erotic Poems from the Sanskrit* (2017). I have not read the translations and so cannot comment on them. But the anthology was a literary event in the late 1970s.

The English chains

Parthasarathy was then working at Oxford University Press and there were two anthologies that began the process of fashioning the canon of Indian poetry in English. One was by Parthasarathy and the other by Mehrotra. One had 10 Indian poets, the other 12. Both featured a single woman poet: in Parthasarathy's case, Kamala Das, and in Mehrotra's, Eunice de Souza. Jeet Thayil's *The Penguin Book of Indian Poets* (2022) features 94 poets and 49 are women.

At the time, these inclusions and exclusions seemed to matter a lot more than they do now and so

Memories (Clockwise from left) A sketch of R. Parthasarathy by artist Jatin Das; the poet with his wife and grandson in New York; and some of his books. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Partha was the dearest friend of mine, from the very beginning; we knew each other from our Bombay days. We had a poetry group at the Samovar cafe in Jehangir Art Gallery. We also had a poetry group in Delhi. I did a portrait of him in Delhi in 2014. So many memories, days spent together... we always kept in touch, even after he left for the U.S. He was the last and the closest one from our Bombay days who has now gone. I miss him dearly

JATIN DAS
Artist

Parthasarathy counted for a lot more than. I have lost track of how many anthologies of Indian poetry in English have now come out in India and abroad. Most of the Indian ones are exploitative; the publishers do not pay the poets. One is supposed to be content with the compliment of inclusion.

Parthasarathy's post-colonial predicament also seems a little dated. 'Whoring after English gods'? That would be one way of looking at

it. As self-implication it is a powerful and resonant line but I don't think anyone sees their 'tongue in English chains' as Parthasarathy says he did.

As a boy, the poet lived in Bombay where he had Hindi on the streets, Tamil at home, English at Don Bosco's School where the Salesian brothers made special arrangements for him to study Sanskrit. If he saw the English language as chains, it was because he had chosen those chains. One could argue that English was the language of power, that choosing this was no choice really for a man born in 1934, but every choice can be parsed similarly.

A slow fade

I never did meet Parthasarathy. He comes to me through anecdotes. In his book of poems for the young at heart, *The Tattooed Teetotaller* (2021), Jussawalla credits the line 'Tickle the Teats of a Tattooed Teetotaller' to an experiment with *bhang* that involved poet-critic Dilip Chitre, Parthasarathy and himself. "I never saw Partha laugh so much," he says.

In the section called 'Exile' in 'Rough Passage', there is a portion that begins with the lines: *Through holes in a wall, as it were, lamps burned in the fog. In a basement flat, conversation filled the night, while Ravi Shankar, cigarette stubs, empty bottles of stout and crisps provided the necessary pauses.*

"That was a Christmas eve or Christmas party. I was in Leeds where Partha was and this was a borrowed flat that was low on crockery of any kind. There was Lancelot Ribeiro [F.N. Souza's half-brother] and Partha and me. We ate tinned food, sausages and things like that, out of teacups because there was nothing else." Jussawalla says there was conviviality. The poets knew each other, they respected each other's choices.

And Parthasarathy's slow fade was one of the many choices that poets make.

The writer is a poet and novelist.

Kanika Sharma

In writing *Women Without Men* (*Zanan bedun-e Mardan*), Shahnush Parsipur gave her female characters a freedom that cost her her own. Set against the CIA-backed 1953 coup in Iran, the novella follows five women – a sex worker, a schoolteacher, a menopausal housewife, and two unmarried women – all seeking escape from the religious diktats governing their lives. In the book, virginity is divorced from honour, and shame is cast aside to create identity.

The vision was radical for its time. Published in 1989, the book appeared just as Iran was consolidating itself as an Islamic Republic. As the state moved to institutionalise hijab and Sharia-based law, Parsipur's fantastical tale was seen as an act of insurrection. She was jailed and the book was banned.

Yet, the novella has outlasted its censors. Circulating underground for decades, it went on to become one of the most discussed works of modern Persian literature, even fuelling the 'Woman, Life, Freedom (*Jin, Jiyan, Azadi*)' movement that shook Iran in 2022. This defining book, newly translated by Faridoun Farrokhi and published by Penguin International Writers, appears on the 2026 longlist of the International Booker Prize – 37 years after its publication.

On a video call from her home in California, 80-year-old Parsipur leans closer to the screen when I mention the nomination. "It hasn't won yet," she says in broken English, her eyes lighting up, belying the decades of exile that have led to this moment.

"From the time I was a little girl, I wanted to be a writer," she later writes in Persian over email. "Back then, I did not have a concept of myself as man or woman writing books for men or women. Even today, I don't necessarily write for women. I write for both men and women."

A political act

Parsipur turned to literature seeking answers to questions typical of adolescence. What is right? What is the meaning of life? How should one live? At 28, her definition of right and wrong collided with politics.

Working as a producer at National Iranian Radio and Television, she resigned in protest against the execution of two Tehran poets. Consequently, she was put behind bars for almost two months.

"It was the first time I had committed a political act," says Parsipur. "Human beings are a political species as well as capable of laughter. Like everyone else, I exist in a political society. I have always opposed political hegemony in Iran and in the U.S. as well, but in America, I am comfortable with its democratic ambience."

After her release, Parsipur moved to Paris where she studied Chinese, Indian and Iranian mythology. Her fascination with myth and symbolism later shaped *Women Without Men*, which she initially wanted to write as 12 short stories of women from the 12 signs of astrology.



The significant role played by such luminaries as Parsipur cannot be underrated. Parsipur's literary genius, and her penetrating insight into the intricacies of the man-woman relationship and its social background, provides a roadmap... Certainly, the recent uprising of women in Iran can be partially attributed to the writings of Parsipur and women of her ilk

FARIDOUN FARROKH
Translator, *Women Without Men*

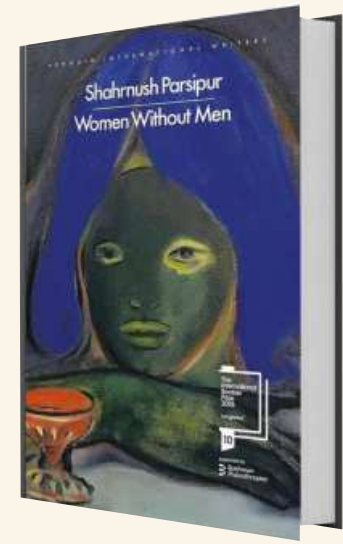


ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

IN CONVERSATION

From prison to prize list

Exiled Iranian writer Shahnush Parsipur on her International Booker Prize-nominated novella about women's lives and freedom

At 34, Parsipur returned to Iran to witness the Iranian Revolution. But the upheaval that followed proved even more dangerous for dissident writers. She was arrested again because political documents were reportedly found in the possession of her brother and mother. She spent nearly five years in prison without formal charges.

As she witnessed thousands of executions around her, Parsipur's longing for freedom seeped into

Women Without Men.

"Magic realism gave me the freedom to do everything that I liked. For example, I could let my character become a bird or an animal and even an angel," she says. And as she wrote, her imagination was seized by the construct of virginity, an idea she had grown up with, internalising patriarchy. "When I was still a child, my grandmother had told me that if a girl lost her virginity, God would

Author Shahnush Parsipur; and (below) a march in Berlin, 2023, to commemorate the death anniversary of student Mahsa Amini. (GETTY IMAGES)



never forgive her," she recalls.

In Iranian schools at the time, there was no such thing as sex education. "Throughout my adolescence and early youth, I thought of virginity and considered it as specific to the female body as breasts."

After much mulling over, Parsipur considered the duality of the construct and felt compelled to dismantle it. "When I realised that virginity is also a state of mind, I wrote the two stories of Faezeh and Munis that end up in *Women Without Men*," she says. "At the time, I never thought of the cultural significance of this issue until I was arrested and imprisoned by the Islamic Republic."

The idea of paradise

Eventually, *Women Without Men* gained stronger resonance as it came to be translated into several languages. "Following the so-called Islamic Revolution of the mid-70s, there was a massive migration of mostly upper- and middle-class Iranians. Many significant works of Iranian literature, including *Women without Men*, found their way into the culture of these and surrounding minority communities in European and American population centres," says academic Faridoun Farrokhi, translator of *Women without Men*. Parsipur believes that the

novella's brevity has helped it travel across cultures while the women's movement in Iran has continued to intensify. In 2022, the death of 22-year-old Mahsa Amini due to alleged police brutality rekindled the debate on state control over women's bodies.

Parsipur is cautious commenting on the current political state of Iran, though she agrees the role of women writers has expanded manifold. "The false notion about Iranian women is that they have no liberties at all. Of course, at this time they have been severely curtailed. But, intellectually, Iranian women have many liberties. That is why there are so many female writers in Iran. They have discovered writing as the most effective way of attracting attention to their ideals."

In that act of imagination, Parsipur's garden of Karadj in the novella also carries echoes of a paradise or a new dawn where women will suffer no shame or tether their sense of worth to men. As fiction often stems from memory, so did the mythical place.

"The idea of paradise entered world literature through Iran," she explains. In a land shaped by arid landscapes, gardens represent a rare oasis of beauty and abundance. "As a child, I slept in one of these gardens. The experience proved unforgettable and became the inspiration for the creation of this story."

Years later, that mythical garden has become a symbol of hope and resilience. "With the death of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and an on-going war there will be major changes," she says, emphasising that she is completely against this war. Yet she hopes this time of churn may open a new chapter for Iranian women.

"We could hope women will wear mini *jupes*, remove their headscarves or engage in more dating and drinking. If the Islamic Republic collapses, there will be further freedom for women. Many paths may open to them, even in politics."

(Shahnush Parsipur's quotes have been translated here from the Persian by Faridoun Farrokhi.)

The writer is a freelance journalist with bylines in leading international and Indian publications.

Life in the Himalaya

Anuradha Roy writes with affection, not sentimentality, about her house, garden and the mountains

Neha Sinha

In Julian Barnes’ 2011 novel, *The Sense of an Ending*, the protagonist asks, “This was another of our fears: that Life wouldn’t turn out to be like Literature. Look at our parents – were they the stuff of Literature?” While working on a memoir, a writer may wonder if she must exaggerate her life, romanticise it, or paint herself, the protagonist, as a hero, as fiction often tends to do, to depict Life with a capital ‘L’. In *Called By The Hills: A Home in the Himalaya*, Anuradha Roy writes her first non-fiction book, a memoir on her life in the Himalaya, in the town of Ranikhet in Uttarakhand, but she chooses understatement over hyperbole.

This becomes important especially because this book is based on, and situated in, the warming Himalayan mountains. These days, works on the Himalaya usually tend to be manifestoes that talk about ‘saving’ the mountains, while also lending importance to the narrator. Roy’s gaze goes beyond such agendas. She does not underline her own material sacrifices. She does not idealise the Himalaya. Instead, she suffuses the book with humour, which bolsters ordinary living.

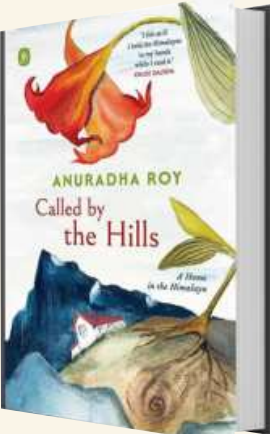
Roy’s cottage garden is wilful, and her attempts to create a colourful, carefully careless site, are repeatedly thwarted. The garden quickly turns into a metaphor for bigger things, including the forests, which have their own agency, and the manner in which one feels very small before a Himalayan storm, both cradled and humbled by the mountains.

The book shuns any performative narratives of a ‘great escape’ to the hills and resists neat classification. Just as you think you are reading cosy cottagecore, ambling through a writer’s life in a charmed part of the world, the book nudges you with the mundane and harsh light of facts. On an important day, the rain gets into her studio. There are no vegetables of choice in the claptrap market. Money runs out, but the demands of life don’t. A dog goes missing.

The slopes and forests are at once wounded and menacing; fragile and picturesque. About a rockslide, she writes: “To stop would have meant getting buried alive.”

Roy writes with affection, but not sentimentality, about her house, her garden, and the mountains. At less than 200 pages, this is a slim book. It meanders towards purpose in the way the author herself walks the slopes – at her own pace, a slow unfurling, never to conquer the slope. The slope is a metaphor that

runs through the book – her own description of going “gently sideways” if deprived of writing, a carpenter who has spent his life in the hills and only makes sloped shelves, and how the slopes bring harsh sunlight and too much shade. She learns that in the Himalaya, things take their own time. Here, “time is neither clockable nor divisible into discrete segments”, she writes. “It is a thing that can stretch when the day is beautiful and there is tea and conversation; it can feel dangerously brief, as when there is a landslide and you have to navigate past falling rocks to a place of safety. In the garden, time can come to a standstill, especially when you are waiting for winter to end, for the pale points of bulbs to break through the hard and frozen earth.” There are also meditations on the craft of writing. Though she doesn’t explicitly say so, we get glimpses of



Called by the Hills: A Home in the Himalaya
Anuradha Roy
John Murray/Hachette India
₹999

what may have informed the writing of her 2011 novel, *The Folded Earth*, which traces the story of Maya who settles in the Himalaya in order to leave grief behind. Maya encounters an assortment of neighbours and the unique demands of mountain life. Her journey is as much inward as outward: “I was going to be two thousand kilometres from anything I knew, but that was just numbers. In truth, the distance was beyond measurement,” she says. *The Folded Earth* was a precursor to *Called by the Hills*. It is a credit to Roy’s skill that she now presents non-fiction in a way that is just as compelling as fiction; that she unearths life’s little truths while resisting the spiel of self-help; that she writes as adeptly about death as she does about the courage of living.

The writer is a conservation biologist and the author of Wild Capital: Discovering Nature in Delhi (2026).



THE ART OF BEING CHAPAL

Sandip Roy’s biography traces the performances, complex identity and subtle queerness of Chapal Bhaduri, the last female impersonator of Bengali *jatra*

Vikram Phukan

In *Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal*, biographer Sandip Roy explores the life and times of Chapal Bhaduri, the last great female impersonator of Bengali *jatra*. He opens with a rigorous introduction that establishes a clear interpretative frame. This is then gradually neutralised by a first-person voice presented as Chapal’s own, though clearly mediated and shaped by an archivist’s eye. Brief dramatised testimonials from those on the periphery of Chapal’s life interject the narrative, and there is a profusion of detail, which can at first feel unwieldy. But once the reader settles into the loose format, the result is a readable and often compelling account.

The childhood section is bookended by Rabindranath Tagore’s funeral procession, rendered with neatness through the image of a toddler spontaneously breaking into dance, and the death of Chapal’s mother, the pre-Independence stage actor, Prabha Devi. It is an origin myth formed within a powerful maternal universe of recipes, plays, performances, and theatrical lineage, and Chapal’s tentative steps into performing as a female entity on stage.

Once this is established, Roy attempts to sketch a hazy lineage of female impersonators, though it operates more through succession than influence. Chapal himself does not consciously inherit this hierarchy: his most formative model is his mother, whose femininity he observed and absorbed. This becomes evident at his debut in a leading role in *Chand Bibi*, when an ageing performer who had once played the part urges him to “do him proud”. Chapal receives the appeal with open scorn. This ethos is sharpened by small, unsparing reversals, as when Chapal, once mistreated by the ‘queen’ he replaced, later replicates that cruelty; elsewhere, a veteran reduced to the comic role of a milkmaid patiently learns, alone, to fashion a pot that



What distinguishes the biography is Roy’s refusal to freeze Chapal Rani at the point of legend. Declared past his prime too soon, as prima donnas often are, Chapal’s withdrawal from the *jatra* spotlight might easily have marked the end of narrative interest

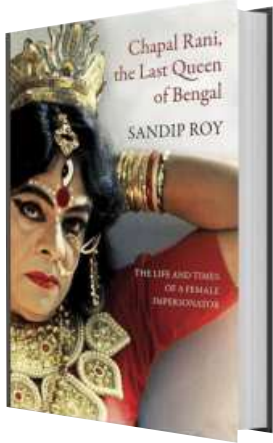
will balance on his head. Roy builds this world incrementally with archival discipline. What passes between impersonators, he appears to suggest, is not tradition or solidarity but cold technique – how to perform an ersatz femininity that can be learned but not owned. Offstage, these men shared rooms with other male actors, and moved through life without a protected space for their femininity. Chapal’s success in women-centric productions placed him in implicit competition with male stars in a way unavailable to female leads.

The world of *jatra* whirs in the background, accumulating texture as Roy inserts excerpts from landmark plays. Though framed as scenes Chapal remembers by heart, the method reveals an instinct to gather these fragments and scatter them headlong into the narrative stream. This mirrors

Chapal’s adult entry into performance as Morjina in *Ali Baba*, thrust onstage with the rebuke that the scene is “flowing by”.

Roy treats *jatra* as a current within which Chapal’s life unfolds. The book does not attempt to assess the form’s excesses, aesthetics, or even its subversive possibilities; *jatra* simply is, carrying successes, failures, and audience devotion along with it. If anything, Roy pays homage to a form often derided with casual contempt, without attempting rehabilitation, and shielded by the omniscient first-person voice.

What distinguishes the biography is Roy’s refusal to



Chapal Rani, the Last Queen of Bengal: The Life and Times of a Female Impersonator
Sandip Roy
Seagull
₹999

Success in women-centric productions often put Chapal Bhaduri in competition with male stars. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

freeze Chapal Rani at the point of legend. Declared past his prime too soon, as prima donnas often are, Chapal’s withdrawal from the *jatra* spotlight might easily have marked the end of narrative interest. Instead, Roy devotes nearly half the book to an autumnal phase, which allows Chapal to exist not as a historical snapshot but as a life extended across changing forms of labour, visibility, and value, without diminishing returns. Even the present-day setting of the old-age home is rendered without pathos; it is just another lived context, in marked contrast to the depiction of his mother’s final years in a play that deeply offended him. This emphasis on duration over climax allows Roy to capitalise on Chapal’s prior persistence in the cultural landscape, through his semi-autobiographical theatre and artefacts of canonisation, such as Kaushik Ganguly’s *Arekti Premier Golpo* and Naveen Kishore’s *Performing the Goddess*.

For a stretch, queerness in the book appears only in faint traces. In an early instance, Chapal declines a male lead role and instead suggests other male actors he would rather play opposite. This suggests a same-sex frisson that is enjoyed on stage, yet never expressed as personal identity. Under Roy’s ethical restraint yet patient coaxing, this eventually expands into a chapter on love, where the book finally edges the closet open, even as Chapal refuses its language.

His verisimilitude as a stage diva repeatedly attracts male suitors, some of whose advances he accepts and others he refuses, without treating either choice as requiring explanation or self-definition. Crucially, Chapal’s performances were not built around the exhibition of femininity itself, but around inhabiting a wide spectrum of women characters for whom gender functioned as a given condition of the role. Yet, a chapter devoted to the meditative preparation for a performance, through costume, ornaments, and make-up, offers a glimpse of an electric gender transference.

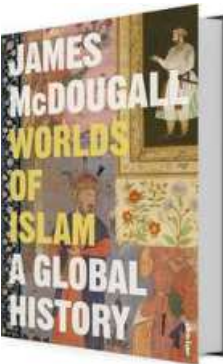
The book is part of Seagull Books’ Pride List, but Roy’s introduction warns against reading Chapal’s life as queer in contemporary terms. The narrative that follows does the heavy lifting, drawing undeniable queer meaning from the lived contradictions of a true icon.

The writer is a Mumbai-based theatre practitioner, stage commentator, and artistic director of Theatre Jil Jil Ramamani.

BROWSER

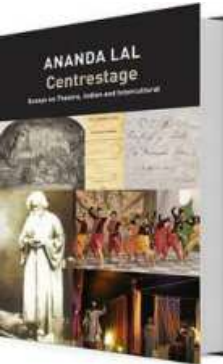
Worlds of Islam: A Global History

James McDougall
Penguin Random House
₹1,299
McDougall traces the evolution of Islam from its origins in 7th century Arabia through its transformations from Late Antiquity to the digital age. His book, *A History of Algeria*, was named one of the *Financial Times*’ best books of the year.



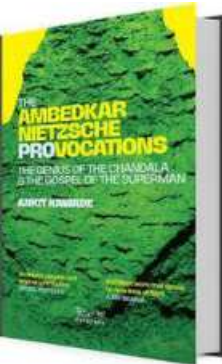
Centrestage: Essays on Theatre, Indian and Intercultural

Ananda Lal
Navayana Books
₹699
The theatre scholar traces the evolution of Indian drama in English from its emergence in the mid-19th century to the diverse and sometimes contentious plays of the 21st century.



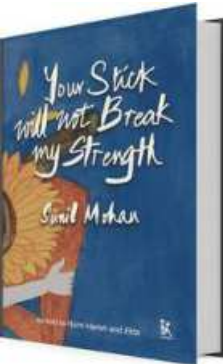
The Ambedkar –Nietzsche Provocations

Ankit Kawade
Navayana Publishing
₹499
The first comprehensive study of the parallels and divergences between B.R. Ambedkar and Friedrich Nietzsche. Kawade is a doctoral candidate at Johns Hopkins University. This is his debut book.



Your Stick Will Not Break My Strength

Sunil Mohan.
As told to Rumi Harish and Ekta Zubaan
₹595
In this memoir, a trans person writes about their struggles with masculinity after transitioning, reflecting on identity, resistance, and the emotional terrain of selfhood.



CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

With a banner year, Warner Bros. Discovery was considered hot property and suitors lined up to buy the huge Hollywood conglomerate. But with Paramount in the picture, Netflix walked away from the bid, albeit with a small benefit – a \$2.8 billion payoff from Paramount.

Theatres versus streaming Netflix's offer scared many in Hollywood. Netflix co-CEO Ted Sarandos has often expressed his aversion to theatrical releases and would much rather bring films directly to his streaming platform. Last year at the Time100 summit, Sarandos said the theatre model was "outdated". "Theatres are not their business model," Pandya says about Netflix. "Their business is streaming, and they want all content to go to streaming first. Many years ago, they started with DVD rentals of movies, but now everything is streaming – films, shows, live events, sports, boxing matches, concerts."

Filmmaker-actor Shekhar Kapur believes the Hollywood landscape is changing. "I remember a top Hollywood studio head telling me, 'We don't do drama'," Kapur says. "I thought, what is storytelling without drama?" Of course, by drama he means dramatic storytelling. "The best writers and storytellers have moved to OTT," he says. "There's a concern in Hollywood that Netflix is the killer of theatrical releases. I don't think so. Theatrical films have moved towards 'ride' movies or Marvel tentpole films where popcorn sales are high." During the negotiations with Warner, Sarandos did say



ELEVEN OSCARS AND A TAKEOVER

that Netflix would honour a 45-day exclusive run window for films to screen in theatres before they came to the streaming service. In recent years, they released the second and third parts of the *Knives Out* franchise films in theatres, although just for a couple of weeks. Even Guillermo Del Toro's *Frankenstein* first got a limited theatrical release, perhaps because the film had the potential for a number of Oscar nominations. Or it was just that Sarandos wanted to keep an Oscar-winning director of Del Toro's stature happy.

Will the merger impact India? Had the Netflix-Warner Bros. Discovery deal gone through, it would have benefitted the streamer's subscribers outside the U.S. – including in India. In India, we were able to watch *Frankenstein* and *Wake Up Dead Man (Knives Out: Part 3)* the same time it became available to U.S. Netflix members. In comparison, *Marty Supreme*, a film that

carried huge Oscar buzz, opened in Indian theatres one month after its U.S. release. The merger will hardly have any implications on the Indian market, according to Siddharth Roy Kapur, founder of Roy Kapur Films and former managing director of Walt Disney Company India. "These players really are distributors of their Hollywood content in India, rather than local producers. As far as I know, they are still going to be releasing their movies theatrically." "The movies that work in India are the superhero franchises, the disaster features with some sense of scale and spectacle," Roy Kapur continues. "And those films, by both Paramount and Warner, will continue to be produced." Consolidations and mergers of studios are never good news for creative people, Roy Kapur agrees. "But these studios aren't producing locally in India." The first major Bollywood production of

Warner Bros. was Nikkhil Advani's *Chandni Chowk to China* (2009) but that experiment did not go down well at the box office, and while they also co-produced Manoj Bajpayee-starrer *Dus Tola* (2010), Warner Bros. had scaled back its production efforts in India. Aamir Khan's *Laal Singh Chaddha* (2022) was jointly co-produced by Paramount Pictures, Aamir Khan Productions and Viacom18 Studios. The film



(Clockwise from far left) Paramount Skydance CEO David Ellison (second from left) with actor Tom Cruise; David Zaslav (left) of Warner Bros. and Netflix's Ted Sarandos; Ellison at *Top Gun: Maverick* premiere; and Warner studio heads Pamela Abdy and Michael De Luca. (GETTY IMAGES)



performed poorly, earning only \$15 million globally. Occasionally, Paramount distributes Indian films, including *Padmaavat* (2018). Currently, both Paramount and Warner stream their shows and films on JioHotstar in India. These include the *Mission Impossible* films (Paramount) and a range of HBO shows such as *Sopranos*, *Game of Throne* and *Succession* (all Warner).

The politics of control David Ellison has promised to keep the two studios – Paramount and Warner Bros. – as separate entities, and each will produce approximately 15 films per year. Amid worries among observers, popular film blog *FirstShowing.net* editor-critic Alex Billington chooses to stay "optimistic". He says, "I don't think it's going to kill Hollywood, but I do

happens, then you see the output dropping," he says. "I hope it doesn't. Because it's great for the creative community to have these strong studios independent of each other." Jane Fonda who was married to the late Ted Turner, founder of CNN, also said the merger would result in political control over the news channel. "That's why [U.S. defence secretary Pete] Hegseth said, 'CNN can't come soon enough' to be under the control of Paramount."

A recent *The New York Times* podcast, too, suggested that Ellison wants to buy all the Warner Bros. Discovery properties so as to control and change the political views expressed on CNN. The news channel is President Trump's least favourite outlet, and he often refers to it as "fake news". Paramount Skydance has done the same with the CBS channel, cancelling Stephen Colbert's popular *The Late Show*. The move was seen by many as a way to curb the anti-Trump chatter on Colbert's show.

Meanwhile, Larry Ellison has been actively developing a new Artificial Intelligence (AI) infrastructure at Oracle. When it comes to having access to data in the form of film, news and social media, with the hope of training AI models, Warner's large library could come in handy. How the deal pans out, one has to wait and watch. The larger Paramount-Warner studio would want to balance big money-earning franchises with critically acclaimed, award-worthy dramas. But Warner Bros.' winning streak at the box office should continue through 2026. Its next DC Studios franchise film *Supergirl* opens this summer, and *Dune: Part 3* is well timed for the Christmas holidays.

The writer is a film festival programmer and author.



Priya Seth

'Where are you going to get experience if no one gives you a break?'

Arkapaw's Oscar is inspiring but bittersweet for Seth. Within hours of the win, the Indian Women Cinematographers Collective (IWCC) chat, of which she is a member, had shifted from celebration to frustration. "Along with the great news, there were so many heartbreaking stories," she says. A crowdsourced list of biases followed: "If I shoot with a woman DP, the work will be too slow"; 'too many women on the crew already'."

After 90-plus years of slow change, "the words haven't changed; the approach hasn't changed," says Seth, who made her feature debut with *Barah Aana* in 2009 and navigates ad films, features and web-series. Barriers are now less about

technical skill or physicality than access and bias. Hiring decisions often cite lack of experience while denying women the chance to build it. "Where are you going to get experience if no one gives you a break?" she asks. Even after shooting large-scale action and war films such as *Airlift* (2016) and *Pippa* (2023), momentum didn't automatically follow. Physicality myths persist, she says. "It's about skill, preparation, and focus."

Allyship is crucial, she says, crediting director Raja Menon for backing her consistently. "You cannot do this alone. Someone has to be willing to go out on a limb for you." Seth's framing and empathy shaped the story in both *Airlift* and *Pippa* (pictured), Menon notes.



THE INHERITANCE OF A WIN

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1



Precetha Jayaraman

'We have to normalise women behind the camera'

"We've always been aware that we are a minority, not just in India but globally," says Jayaraman, noting that only four women had been nominated for cinematography in nearly a century of Academy Awards. With over 20 years in the industry, working across Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam and Hindi films, including *Vaanam Kottatam* (2020) and *Bad Girl* (2025) (pictured), she believes that opportunity is the main barrier for women behind the camera, and says, "the calls don't come". Visibility matters beyond the crew, she says, "When the camera



is in a woman's hands, perspective changes. People see relationships, emotion and nuance differently. That is powerful." Trained under veteran cinematographer P.C. Sreeram, she notes, mentorship is key. "We have to be visible, to speak up about challenges, to normalise women behind the camera. That's the only way systemic change happens."



Modhura Palit

'Staying seen and continuing to do my work, that is a triumph'

Simply wanting to "do cinematography" landed Palit at Kolkata's Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute, where she was the only woman across three batches. Entering the profession, her awareness sharpened: "Nobody asked me about my work. They asked if I could lift the camera." The challenge was less about proving skill than dismantling assumptions.

Opportunities are still filtered through bias. "Filmmakers decide what women can shoot," Palit says, explaining how projects are often framed around notions

of "sensitive handling", narrowing both the work and perception of women DOPs. On set, authority matters. "If they see you know your job, they don't care if you're a woman or man. Then, they become your biggest supporters." Palit rejects simplistic ideas of a "female gaze", emphasising that differences in visual approach are often overstated.

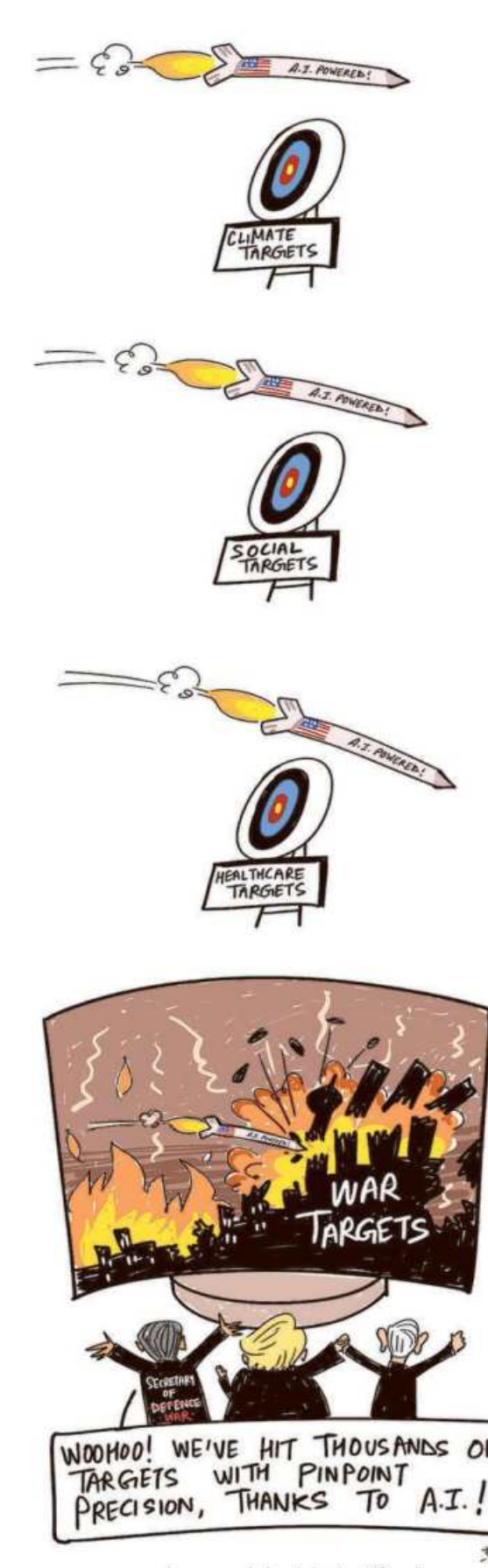
Palit's filmography spans regional films, including *Ami O Manohar* (2018), *Amar Colony* (2022), and *Bahadur: The Brave* (2023) (pictured). She won the Pierre Angénieux Excellens award at the 2019 Cannes Film Festival, a recognition she describes as "a reminder that women can lead visually, even in spaces historically dominated by men". She stresses mentorship and visibility as crucial. "If young women see someone like me doing this work, it shows them it's possible."

The writer is a Mumbai-based freelance journalist who writes on cinema.



GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Shrabonti Bagchi

In February this year, Prayag, a children's library based in Gopalganj, Bihar, organised a children's literature festival, Udaan, at the Bihar Museum in Patna. Over two days, hundreds of school and college students, educators and parents attended the festival, which was largely considered a success, except for one unsavoury incident.

On the very first day of the festival, a visitor going through the books at a stall put up by Mumbai-based independent publishing platform Blue Jackal, which specialises in comics and visual narratives, started arguing about the content of several of their children's books. His attention first landed on the comic book *Chudail* by Lokesh Khodke from Blue Jackal, which depicts a Brahmin woman being possessed by a demon that shows her how unfair her life is. "He asked me what the book was about and I explained it in brief. Then suddenly, he said, 'Oh, so this *chudail* can only enter a Brahmin woman's body and not any other?'" I told him that this was a creative writing technique and the writer was using the *chudail* (witch) as a metaphor, that it's a conversation between these two characters," says Shefalee Jain, one of the other members of Blue Jackal who was managing their stall that day.

"But he was not there to listen. He started saying our books were anti-Brahmin, anti-national. He started picking up one book after another, rifling through them, and taking panels and dialogues out of context," says Jain. Soon, the man started threatening to summon other people to shut down the stall and file an FIR. When the Blue Jackal team returned to the festival the next day, their stall had been dismantled.

The incident spurred the publishing house to look at the landscape of artistic freedom in the country, and the way narratives and voices from the margins are being suppressed because they are deemed "anti-Brahminical" or "anti-national". There have been several such incidents in the recent past. A book discussion on *The Cell and the Soul: A Prison Memoir*, featuring activist and academic Anand Teltumbade at the Kala Ghoda Arts Festival in Mumbai, was cancelled



DRAWING THE LINE

India's artist fraternity is uniting to devise meaningful responses to growing censorship

last month. The Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC), under the Ministry of Information & Broadcasting, denied permission to screen *Dalit Kids*, a Malayalam animated short by film students Appu Soman and Tony Joppan, at the Anima Animation Festival in Mumbai last month.

How to respond All these incidents – by no means an exhaustive list – are noted in a statement drafted by Blue Jackal in consultation with several members of the comic-book community, including independent publishers,

children's book publishers, individual artists and illustrators and several organisations that work in the children's literary space. Titled "Collective Statement Against Recurring Stifling of Creative and Critical Voices Across the Country", the statement has been signed by around 300 members of the artistic fraternity in India, and calls out the "rising culture of intolerance and suppression". "We position these incidents within the rising suppression and censorship of the work of artists, authors and educators – especially our rights and freedoms to dissent

against power and injustice. We then strongly assert that these disruptions set a dangerous precedent if left unaddressed in the current political climate and ponder about the permitted limits of inclusivity that institutional spaces allow," the statement reads. The intent is also to go beyond recording these incidents and formally protesting them to find ways in which people and organisations working with marginalised communities can formulate standard ways of responding and safeguarding themselves against threats of

violence and disruption. "I am supporting the statement and want to say if there is a way a process can be set up to respond in meaningful ways when something like this happens – a protocol of sorts with best practices, legal advice, how to push back and how much," says artist Rohan Chakravarty.

There is also the question of how much institutional support they can expect, says Jain. When the incident in Patna happened last month, the

► **Space for dialogue** (Clockwise from left) Visitors at the Udaan Children's Literature Festival in Patna; a panel from comic book *Chudail*, which stirred a controversy; and actor Naseeruddin Shah at the first lecture organised by Mumbai For Peace. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Blue Jackal team was disappointed in the way the festival organisers and even other attendees failed to stand by them or present solutions in a unified way (Prayag, which organised the Udaan festival, declined to comment).

"We don't want to let it go in silence, because there is an endless number of such incidents that happen in university spaces and outside of them, which are hushed up because of fear. And so such

elements get more and more emboldened. So we want to push back," says Jain.

Act of solidarity Institutions are constantly treading a thin line between protecting themselves and the idea of artistic freedom, says V. Ravichandrar, the Bengaluru-based founder of cultural spaces like the Bangalore International Centre and Sabha BLR, and a key organiser of festivals like the Bangalore Literature Festival and BLR Hubba. "This is a continuous challenge, and a lot of us are self-censoring and playing it safe. 'Will this event cause problems? Do we have all the representative voices? Is this a contentious issue?' This is something that crops up in our minds and conversations again and again," says Ravichandrar, who believes institutions should not be blindsided by people taking offence or making threats of disruption.

"At BIC, we adopt a pragmatic stance, prioritising the institution's interests and its role as a balanced platform for diverse voices. The goal is to live to fight another day," he adds.

One of the ways some members of civil society are pushing back is by simply relocating and rescheduling events that are cancelled without any explanation by organisers. Recently, the Mumbai-based citizen group Mumbai For Peace started a series of lectures called 'Lectures that needed to happen' after a talk and reading by actor Naseeruddin Shah was suddenly cancelled by University of Mumbai. The group quietly rescheduled the event and held it at a different venue. Just last week, feminist historian Uma Chakravarti's lecture at SNDT university was cancelled and later held by Mumbai For Peace at another location.

"We had a workshop a few days ago on being a response team when something like this happens, and also as an act of solidarity with those who belong to marginalised communities and are feeling threatened and vulnerable," says Sujata Gothoskar, a Mumbai-based activist who is a member of Mumbai For Peace. "There has to be some kind of pushback and assertion of love and solidarity and understanding rather than the hate that's happening all around us."

The writer is an independent journalist based in Bengaluru.

ALLEGEDLY

Dictionary of foreign policy

It involves the strategic use of hugs, medals, photo-ops, audio-less videos and more

India's foreign policy can be confusing if your IQ is below 299. So, for the benefit of newcomers suddenly forced to take an interest in it because of the LPG cylinder situation, I've put together a lexicon of key terms.

Strategic autonomy: Originally derived from the Greek term 'stratagos autonomos', in Indian English, it literally means "ask for permission". Some people confuse it with 'strategic autonomy', but it's not the same thing. Strategic autonomy is the doctrine of serially grovelling at the feet of whichever big power is bullying you at any given moment.

For example, if America wants you to stop buying Iranian oil and it is against your national interest to do so, strategic autonomy would dictate that you do it anyway. If the next day, China tells you, "Forget the past, act as if everything is hunky-dory between us," you say, "What past?" The big advantage of strategic autonomy is that it works like a dream when it comes to protecting your strategic autonomy.

Strategic autonomy: it denotes the financial interests of a country's top oligarchs. As a concept, it articulates a foundational principle of liberal democracy – translating financial power into political power. Strategic autonomy is the fuel that lubricates the electoral machinery and expanding inequality in capitalist democracies.

Multi-alignment: The art of buying your groceries (and weapons) from different countries at the same time. So we will buy air defence from Russia, soybean oil from America, and everything else from China. The biggest benefit of multi-alignment is that you are everyone's friend but no one is your friend. For example, Iran was India's good friend, but due to India's multi-alignment, India became Israel's best friend, which is Iran's worst enemy. As a result,

Global South: Opposite of the Global North.

Global North: People we take orders from.

BRICS: A grouping of the leading powers of the Global South, it stands for Brazil, Russia, Iran, China and South Africa (BRICS). India also participates in BRICS proceedings to the extent permitted by pragmatic realism.

Pragmatic realism: Keeping Donald Trump happy.

Strategic patience: Foreign policy in 'safe mode'. It kicks in whenever a potent combination of ignorance, incompetence, cowardice and fear lead to prolonged indecision and the only option left is to sit tight and blame Nehru.

Net security provider: If you are playing football, hockey or water polo in the Indian Ocean and want to ensure that the net doesn't collapse when someone scores a goal, India will function as the net security provider for up to 15 goals as long as the game is played within 12 nautical miles of the Indian coastline.

Constructive engagement: When you have nothing to show for your foreign trip but are too embarrassed to say publicly that the diplomatic meetings were a stupid waste of time, effort and taxpayers' money.

Closely monitoring the situation: Waiting to hear back from the U.S./ Israel/ China.

Comprehensive strategic partnership: A bilateral relationship that is more than 'friends with benefits' but less than a serious commitment.

Strategic restraint: Trump denied permission.

BIMSTEC: Are you serious?

Rules-based international order: LOL

we must stand in line for LPG. LPG: Until recently, a marker of middle class respectability, today it is a symbol of India's strategic autonomy.

Issue-based alignment: Also known as the 'sellout doctrine', it refers to the policy of selling your principles, values, and national sovereignty to the Epstein class.

Epstein class: This definition has been withheld in India in response to a legal demand.

Energy security: Something that is achieved by purchasing oil from wherever you have permission to buy it from at any given time, without going through the hassle of building a long-time strategic reserve or buffer stock of crude.

Trade deal with the U.S.: A trade agreement wherein a country that is not the U.S.

agrees to serve the neo-colonial interests of the U.S., at great cost to the farmers and workers of the country that is not the U.S.

Vishwaguru: A Sanskrit-origin term that literally means 'teacher of the world', it is now in the process of being decommissioned from public service following the extraordinary success of India's multi-alignment strategy.

Managing optics: Also known as the 'philosopher's stone' of India's foreign policy, it refers to the strategic use of hugs, medals, photo-ops, audio-less videos and 'sapna-sapna' to transmute every diplomatic disaster into a global validation of India's standing as an emerging superpower and undisputed leader of the Global South.

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

At Ratan-gad, or Ratanpur Fort, near Bilaspur in Chhattisgarh – once part of Madhya Pradesh – there exists a rare and striking sculpture of Ravana. He is shown cutting off several of his 10 heads and offering it into a sacrificial fire. This scene does not come from Valmiki’s *Ramayana*, but from a later imagination. The offering is made to Brahma in *Mahabharata*’s ‘Ramopakhyana’. And in later regional versions, to Shiva.

This particular image dates to around 1000 CE. Its location is significant, in the region that ancient texts called Dakshina (southern) Kosala. To its north lay Uttara Kosala, Rama’s homeland. To its east was the region that later came to be known as Pashchimi (western) Lanka, now called Odisha. To its south stretched the dense forests of Dandakaranya. This was the deep south of Valmiki’s imagination.

This landscape is bounded by four great rivers. The Ganga to the north, the Godavari to the south, the Mahanadi to the east, and the Narmada to the west. Within this zone grows dense *sala* forests. This is crucial. The Valmiki *Ramayana* repeatedly speaks of *sala* trees. *Sala* forests do not grow in southern India. They grow in central and eastern India, north of Chhattisgarh and closer to the Himalayan foothills. The forest Rama enters is not peninsular Tamilakam or Kerala. It is this Central Indian forest belt.

Rethinking the kingdom
Alongside *sal* grows the Ashoka tree, especially in the wet mountainous regions of Odisha, now known as Mahendragiri. Today, it is the state tree of Odisha. In the *Ramayana*, Sita is held captive in a garden full of



FROM CULT TO CULTURE

THE RAVANA OF RATANPUR

Behind the modern political narratives of the *Ramayana* lie older memories that go back 3,000 years

Ashoka trees. This again points to an eastern-central Indian ecology. When Valmiki speaks of Kishkindha, the land of monkeys, and Lanka, the land of *rakshasas*, this is the south he has in mind, south of *Arya-varta*, a

river-island probably. Not the island we call Sri Lanka today, but the forests and mineral-rich zones of central India. Ratanpur lies in a landscape saturated with the earliest layers of

the *Ramayana* story. Today, we speak of the *Ramayana* as a national epic, but the world it describes is far older. The events it narrates belong to a memory that goes back nearly 3,000 years, in the Vedic period – even though the text itself was composed and consolidated about 2,000 years ago, between the Mauryan and Gupta empires.

The *sala* and Ashoka trees were closely connected with Buddhist lore. Buddha dies between two *sala* trees. He was born under the Ashoka tree. So, Ravana’s Lanka being linked to these two trees cannot be a coincidence. It reflects the Brahmin-Buddhist conflict in the post-Ashokan era.

Something dramatic happens after 1000 CE. The Cholas, locked in conflict with Sri Lankan kings and dependent on copper for their temple bronzes, begin to identify Sri



Battle at Lanka by miniature painter Sahibdin; and (far left) Ratanpur’s Ravana. (WIKI COMMONS, DR. SANJAY SHARMA)

Lanka as Ravana’s Lanka. Cities such as Anuradhapura are plundered. Sinhaladvipa becomes equated with the *rakshasa* kingdom.

This idea is retrospectively reinforced by the *Lankavatara Sutra*, a Mahayana Buddhist text that speaks of the Buddha visiting Lanka and teaching Ravana. The Lanka of this text is symbolic and philosophical, not geographical Sri Lanka. But names stick, and memories shift.

Evolving gods
By the Vijayanagara period, around 1500 CE, under the influence of Madhva Brahmins, hundreds of Hanuman temples were built across the Deccan. The Deccan itself becomes identified with Kishkindha, the land of monkeys. The older memory of Dandakaranya in Chhattisgarh and Central India fades from popular consciousness.

And yet traces remain. River names such as Subarnarekha, cities like Sonpur and Ratanpur, and local legends continue to echo Ravana. The medieval Gond kings of this region, keen to distinguish themselves from Rajput lineages, minted coins claiming descent from

Pulastya, an ancestor of Ravana himself. This happened around the 15th and 16th centuries.

The multi-headed Ravana image also invites another comparison. From around 500 CE, Mahayana Buddhism begins to depict Bodhisattvas with multiple heads and arms, most famously Avalokiteshvara. Early Buddhist images were restrained, with two arms and calm symmetry. Multiplicity enters Buddhist art under Hindu influence, drawing on the idea of Purusha, the cosmic being with many heads and many limbs.

When we study the *Ramayana* alongside sculptures such as the Ravana of Ratanpur, we see a palimpsest. Beneath modern political narratives lie older memories of forests, rivers, rival faiths, shifting geographies, and evolving gods. The epic is not fixed. It remembers what we choose to forget.



Devdutt Pattanaik is the author of 50 books on mythology, art and culture.

GOREN BRIDGE

Wild hand

East-West vulnerable
South deals

Bob Jones

Today’s deal is from a match between a team from Poland and a team from Brazil. At the other table, North passed over West’s three-club bid and there was no more bidding. Three clubs scored nine tricks. At this table, North aggressively supported spades at the three level and South, Polish expert Krzysztof Martens, carried on to game.

Martens ruffed the opening club lead in dummy and led a heart toward his king. East rose with his ace and shifted to a trump, won by Martens in hand. He led the queen of clubs, covered with the king, and ruffed in dummy. East did not over-ruff with his natural trump trick, discarding a diamond instead. Martens led a low diamond from dummy and ruffed East’s queen. He cashed his two top spades, followed by the king of hearts, seeing the queen fall from East. Martens

NORTH		EAST	
♠ 9 6 3		♠ J 7 5 2	
♥ J 9 8 5 3 2		♥ A Q	
♦ K 5 3 2		♦ A Q 10 9 7 4	
♣ Void		♣ 8	
WEST		SOUTH	
♠ 10		♠ A K Q 8 4	
♥ 10 4		♥ K 7 6	
♦ J 8 6		♦ Void	
♣ A K J 10 5 4 3		♣ Q 9 7 6 2	

The bidding:			
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
1♠	3♣	3♠	Pass
4♠	All pass		

Opening lead: Ace of ♣

led a heart to dummy, which East ruffed with his last trump. East led the ace of diamonds, but Martens discarded instead of ruffing and East had to lead a diamond to dummy, giving declarer the rest of the tricks

and his contract. Beautifully done! Note that both East and South made excellent plays when they refused to over-ruff. It was South’s day to come out on top.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

All about acronyms

Berty Ashley

1 On March 22, 1960, Arthur Schawlow and Charles Townes received the first patent for a device they had developed at Bell Labs. It was an extension of their ‘Microwave Amplification by Stimulated Emission of Radiation’ into the optical spectrum. What was the patent for?

2 Frenchmen Émile Gagnan and Jacques-Yves Cousteau invented a device to help them pursue their favourite pastime for longer. They called it the Aqua-Lung, a reference to what it was. Later, Christian Lambertsen coined an acronym for the apparatus. What did he call it?

3 This word is technically an ‘anacronym’, meaning it has lost much of its original acronymic identity. It refers to a system that uses radio waves to detect distance (ranging). What is this system, now written as a regular word rather than an acronym?

4 This six-digit code was introduced on August 15, 1972, by a government entity to streamline services across India. It divides the country into nine geographic regions (eight regional zones and one army zone). What is this code and its full form?

5 This global retailer, which operates in 60-plus countries and sells over €45 billion worth of goods, was founded by Ingvar Kamprad, who was born on a farm called Elmtaryd in the Swedish town of Agunnaryd.



EGOT is the designation given to individuals who have won all four major performing arts awards in the United States. (GETTY IMAGES)

Which company is this?

6 OPEC aims to coordinate policies to ensure stable oil markets and fair returns for producers. Which important

commodity does this organisation of exporting countries regulate, making it crucial to global energy?

7 A popular acronym refers to the grouping of science,

technology, engineering and mathematics. Recently, it has been suggested that art should be included as well to encourage creativity. What is the updated acronym that reflects this change?

8 EGOT is the designation given to individuals who have won all four major performing arts awards in the United States. If the two middle letters stand for the Grammy Award and the Oscar, what do the remaining letters represent?

9 A measure of computer processing speed is expressed in terms such as giga_ and mega_. The missing word refers to “floating-point operations per second”. What is this acronym, which also describes bad movies?

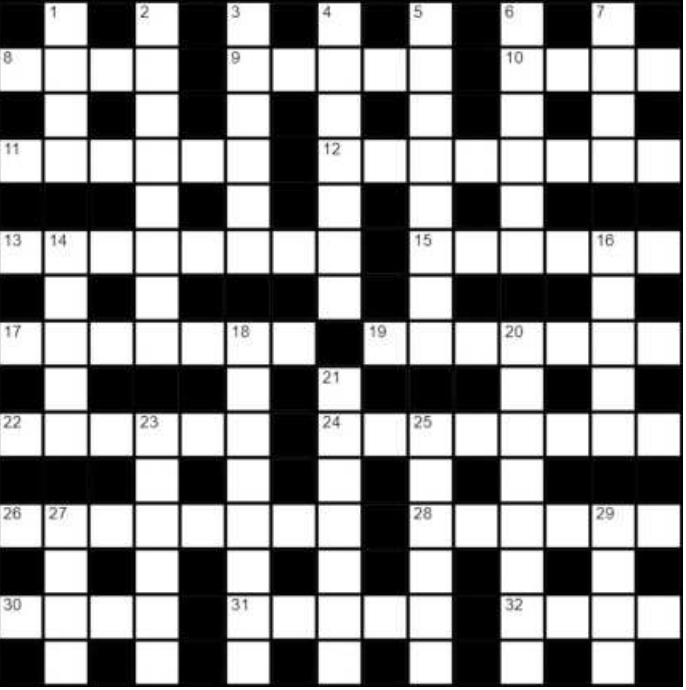
10 Security measure CAPTCHA stands for ‘Completely Automated Public _ _ _ _ Test to Tell Computers and Humans Apart’. Which iconic computer scientist’s name fills the blank?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 10. Turing (after Alan Turing)
- 9. FLOPS
- 8. Emmy Award and Tony Award
- 7. STEAM
- 6. Petroleum (crude oil)
- 5. IKEA
- 4. PIN (postal index number)
- 3. Radar
- 2. SCUBA
- 1. LASER

Answers

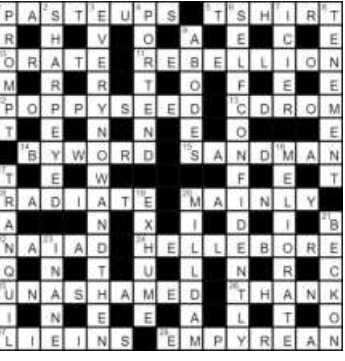
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 48 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
- 8 Pulled and sketched (4)
 - 9 Reduce moisture level around top class type of farm producing milk (5)
 - 10 Island Noah utilised to some extent (4)
 - 11 Says, “It may be United” (6)
 - 12 These are used to supply energy for war horses (8)
 - 13 Final position from one companion after last month (8)
 - 15 Spouse’s relatives, including women, slain horribly (2-4)
 - 17 Give a big smile after tea, resulting in consternation (7)
 - 19 Sees “Best Wishes” (7)
 - 22 Motorist’s club (6)
 - 24 Ten beams wrongly placed in cellar (8)
 - 26 Hated exam indeed! (8)
 - 28 Don’s descendant follows public university teacher initially (4,2)
 - 30 In jail, love attendant (4)
 - 31 I’m leaving Martini cocktail for coach (5)
 - 32 Makes mistake parking costly car in European street at first (4)
- Down**
- 1 Boy with rodent is a troublesome kid (4)
 - 2 Clobbering a teetotaler occupying equipment in playground (8)
 - 3 Port protected by Goddess Athena (6)
 - 4 Jug’s a sports player who stands on a mound (7)
 - 5 Item manufactured by crazy Andy is

- explosive (8)
- 6 After Monday, for starters, go out looking for an East Asian (6)
- 7 Actor from Mancherla (4)
- 14 Violent mudflow in Ambala, Haryana (5)
- 16 Increase breadth of West Indies study (5)
- 18 Pester Ms Hayworth in middle of tortuous rite (8)
- 20 Owned up and took on board (8)
- 21 City’s having an offer by January (7)
- 23 Nine confused in Virginia’s capital (6)
- 25 Little Susan possessing thin brooch is lying (6)
- 27 Looked at storey edited partially (4)
- 29 Blades found in boar skin (4)

SOLUTION NO. 47





The fruits attract several birds and add freshness to the morning hours. GETTY IMAGES

The sapota plant in the backyard

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Some 15 years ago, we moved to an independent house after living in an apartment for over a decade. Our new house was located far away from the city centre, in a quiet area with a village-like charm. It was a small house, with some open area around. All of us were excited, and the first thing we did was to plant several fruit trees, though the space was small. One such tree was a sapota that was planted in a corner behind the house. Our boys were young children, and each day as soon as they got up in the morning would run to inspect and water the plant. Often the sapota plant was a topic of discussion during family time, and everyone was eager to see it flower and produce fruits. My septuagenarian father-in-law during his visits to our house would add further colour to our discussion, sharing stories about his childhood days when every household in Kerala had many fruit trees.

Time slowly passed, and all in the family became busy in their own world. Our children became busy with their studies and moved to colleges to pursue higher studies. My own office work kept me engaged most of the time and all I did was to glance at the poor tree once in a while with a guilty feeling. No one really bothered about the plant, but somehow it seemed to survive the lack of attention. Even in neglect it slowly grew into a healthy strong tree with many branches and soon it started to flower. It bore lots of fruits and once again our attention to the tree was rekindled. Every morning I started to inspect it and even give water though unnecessary. The fruits attracted several birds that chirped and added freshness to the morning hours. Soon our dear sapota tree became a regular discussion topic in the family and our sons were curious to know when they called us from faraway places. In our conversations, I took a special interest in explaining my efforts to ripen them naturally by keeping in paper bags, and describing how sweet the fruits were.

Sometimes I wonder why we humans can't be like trees. Trees share their precious wealth without discrimination or expecting anything in return. They teach us the value of patience and resilience, and importance of sharing.

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In an age when nationalism increasingly presents itself as grievance, and patriotism is confused with hostility towards difference, a question seeks attention. What kind of civilisation is being invoked in the name of the nation? It is understandable that India must imagine its future with pride and not any rancour in its heart. But pride, if it is to transcend mere posturing, must be anchored in memories that unsettle the prevailing ethos of ethnic politics rather than pander to the self-flattering narratives of present-day India.

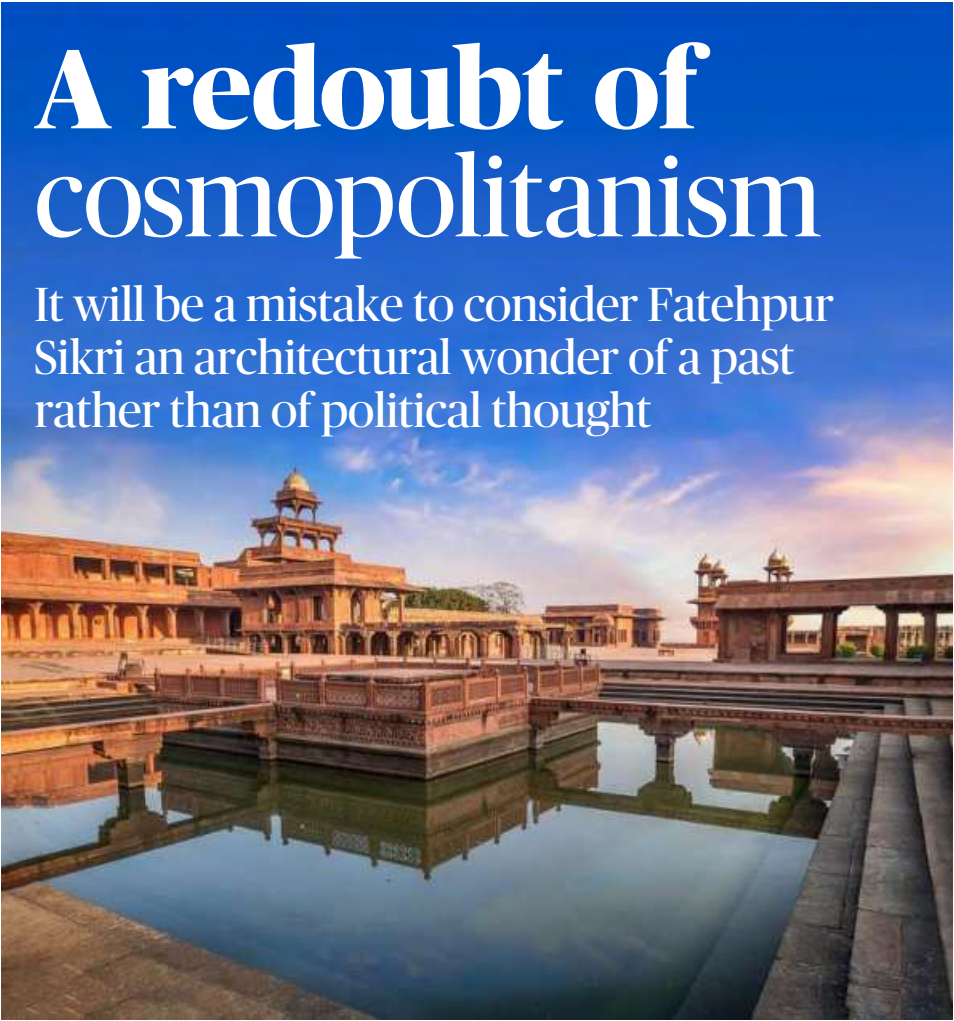
During my recent visit to Fatehpur Sikri, I felt this unsettling quality of the past's proximity, an inescapable sensation manifested palpably in a Proustian reverie of my childhood in the 1950s and 1960s. That was the halcyon era, seemingly untainted by the hardened fault lines of communal discord or the political grammars of difference that would later inscribe themselves upon our social fabric. In that early in-between space, childhood existed before the world began to demand an explanation of sectarian consciousness.

As Walter Benjamin might suggest, Fatehpur Sikri's ruins evoked for me a "Messianic cessation of happening", a jolt that arrests linear time, allowing fragments of the past to erupt into the present. My visit became an act of "brushing history against the grain", thereby interrupting the present narrative of division through childhood memories of times when communal harmony was not a utopian ideal but a given reality.

In an age when Europe was still inching toward what Francis Bacon would later call "the advancement of learning", Fatehpur Sikri had already become a living laboratory of intellectual cosmopolitanism. At the heart of Fatehpur Sikri stands the Ibadat Khana, the House of Worship. Standing there in the silence of a cold winter morning, I could visualise the Sunni and Shia theologians debating alongside Hindu pundits, Jain monks, Zoroastrians, and Jesuit priests, the encounters sustained in a form of brainstorming. Akbar was not seeking a final synthesis, nor endeavouring to declare authority as the final truth, but expose his rule itself to debate. Scholars, missionaries, theologians, Central Asian mystics, artists, architects, and philosophers crossed linguistic and civilisational frontiers to gather at his court, an approach that we later see Rabindranath Tagore introducing in Shantiniketan.

Theatre of ideas

The Ibadat Khana was not merely a hall of worship but a theatre of ideas, where translation, disputation, and philosophical encounter unfolded in real time. One is reminded of Bacon's utopian vision in New Atlantis, the ship that sails across oceans gathering knowledge from distant lands, or even of Napoleon's Egyptian expedition, when defeat at sea did not prevent him from carrying scientists, engineers, astronomers, and archaeologists up the Nile, inadvertently laying the foundations



In an age when Europe was still inching toward what Francis Bacon would later call 'the advancement of learning', Fatehpur Sikri had already become a living laboratory of intellectual cosmopolitanism. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

of Egyptology. Fatehpur Sikri belongs to that larger genealogy of experimental cosmopolitan spaces, a court that imagined empire not simply as territorial dominion, but as the orchestration of knowledge, language, and belief across borders.

Commonly described as a "ghost city", abandoned for logistical reasons, it will be a mistake to consider Fatehpur Sikri an architectural wonder of a past rather than of political thought. What was attempted here in the 16th century was not simply imperial administration, but a civilisational argument about power, belief, and difference. The city matters not because it failed, but because of what it dared to imagine and experiment.

From this practice emerged Sulh-i-Kul, or "peace with all", not as a sentimental ethic, but as a principle of governance. It rejected the assumption, now taken almost for granted, that political stability requires cultural uniformity. In Akbar's imagination, power was strong enough to survive doubt which, to him, was not an administrative inconvenience but a condition of ethical rule.

This confidence is precisely what contemporary nationalism lacks. Across democracies today, the authoritarian turn is overtly proclaimed, but is imperceptibly allowed to proceed through the narrow narratives of ultra-nationalism and belonging. Race, religion, and culture are thereby mobilised as instruments of political consolidation. While dissent is made out to be disloyalty, the minorities are deemed to be demographic threats.

Standing in the midst of such a space, I could feel deep within me its philosophical essence resonate with other subcontinental traditions that

resisted structures of centralised authority. Sikh thought, emerging soon after, made a decisive break by transferring sovereignty from rulers and lineages to the Word. With the declaration of the Guru Granth Sahib as the eternal Guru, authority was removed from charisma, bloodline, and coercion. Truth was placed beyond capture. The Bhakti movement similarly unsettled caste and religious hierarchies through devotion that refused social arrogance. Poets like Kabir dismantled Hindu-Muslim binaries with disarming clarity, insisting that spiritual truth dissolves identity pride. Sufi traditions, with their emphasis on humility and inward ethics, offered another sustained resistance to punitive religion. What unites these traditions is a refusal of the finality of interpretation, of dominance, of the claim that power alone can arbitrate truth. Fatehpur Sikri, therefore, represents power as a process of dialogue. The Diwan-i-Khas, with its central pillar and radiating paths, suggests that multiple perspectives can emerge from a shared space without needing uniformity. To remember Fatehpur Sikri today is for me a political act, challenging the claim that equality, pluralism, and human rights are embedded in our own civilisational experiments, articulated long before modern constitutionalism gave them legal form. The struggle for equality gains strength, not weakness, when anchored in such memory.

My visit to Fatehpur Sikri underscored a crucial question: can a civilisation secure in its identity afford to engage in dialogue, debate, and evolution toward a more humane system? The answer will shape not only the future of pluralism but also the trajectory of democracy itself.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Despite being a vital form of artistic expression and mentorship, drag remains socially misunderstood and legally vulnerable. ('Where queer ambition finds a home'; March 15) Many drag artists face persistent stigma and discrimination. To ensure these creative communities thrive without fear, governments must provide them equal rights and protection from harassment. **N.S. Reddy**

A better future

Authoritarianism is on the rise globally, particularly within established democracies. ('DNA of authoritarianism', March 15) However, as Anne Applebaum says, people should not give up on being optimistic about a change for the better in future. History shows that no authoritarian regime endures indefinitely. **Kosaraju Chandramouli**

Positive impact

SPOT's cafe model deserves serious attention from public health planners elsewhere. ('Brewing courage in Mizoram'; March 15) Stigma, not ignorance, keeps most people away from testing centres. A non-clinical, youth-friendly environment lowers that barrier considerably. **M. Barathi**

Timely revival

The revival of Arabic calligraphy in South India is heartening, but its longevity depends on institutional support beyond social media enthusiasm. ('Ink beyond scripture'; March 15) Initiatives like TNAC and Jamal Mohamed College's

training centre are promising. State art academies and school curricula should formally recognise calligraphy as a visual art discipline. **A. Myilsami**

Although calligraphy was once considered outdated with the rise of digitisation, the very same digital age has unexpectedly helped revive it. Digital art can often appear mechanical and repetitive, while the human touch in calligraphy offers a uniqueness and warmth that captures our attention. **S. Sundareswara Pandiyan**

Superficial affairs

Sandip Roy's column is hilarious and thought-provoking as he subtly highlights the meme trend as a coping strategy. ('Armed with memes'; March 15) These days, everything is on a superficial level and posting on social media takes precedence over all else. The concluding line of the column makes one ponder the current state of affairs. **Saira Banu**

Practical solutions

What distinguishes Jaglan's work is his insistence on engaging men rather than bypassing them. ('Ideas for an equal world'; March 15) Jaglan's approach — tracking household hours, discussing menopause with men, targeting patriarchal assumptions at source — is practically sound. Replication requires documentation and peer networking among sarpanches. Panchayat training modules should incorporate this model formally. **S.M. Jeeva**

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Ageing has been represented in literature in all its complexity and subtle niceties. Its nuances and dynamics have attracted writers down the ages. Decrepitude, disease, and death have fired their imagination. The philosophical musings on death and the poetic meditations on illness seek to define the absurdity of the human condition. The loneliness of the aged and their lived experience often constitute the emotional substratum of the literary text.

Gerontology, the science of ageing, is a multidisciplinary field that deals with the biological, psychological, and social aspects of ageing. The empathy that literature evokes and the subtle shades of human experience it unfolds would give a new dimension to gerontological science and geriatric medicine. Ageing is a social and cultural construct. The venerable old man of a particular historical period or cultural context may degrade into a "paltry thing, a tattered



coat upon a stick" in another. In Shakespeare's *King Lear* (1605), Lear, the senile, narcissistic, volatile and choleric tragic hero, is stripped of his power and authority by his ungrateful daughters. Forlorn and forsaken, he is buffeted by the fury of nature and inner turbulence, which inevitably unhinge him. Suffering transforms him into a

humane and compassionate person who can identify himself with the "poor naked wretches" of the world. Finally, chastened and subdued, he feels excited to be sent to prison with Cordelia, where they would "sing like birds in the cage". But fate has something else in store for them.

Santiago, the old unlucky fisherman in Ernest Hemingway's *The Old Man and the Sea* (1952), is the quintessential existential hero. He has been unable to catch a fish for 84 days. On the 85th day, he hooks a huge marlin and struggles with it for hours before harpooning it. Then, he has to face a new challenge as sharks attack and devour his prized catch. He taps into his reserve energy. The unequal fight goes on until the fish is reduced to a skeleton. Ultimately, the story highlights the themes of perseverance, resilience, pride, and the complex

relationship between man and an indifferent nature. Santiago is trying to find meaning in a meaningless and absurd universe. He takes the responsibility for his existential choices. "Man is not made for defeat. A man can be destroyed, but not defeated." These iconic words of Santiago are redolent of his indomitable spirit.

In Thomas Mann's *Death in Venice* (1912), ageing is central to the physical, moral, and psychological collapse of the protagonist, Gustav Aschenbach, a disciplined and famous German writer. Confronted with a mid-life crisis in creativity precipitated by a structured and rigid life, he leaves for Venice, the city of passion, ecstasy and chaos, hoping to revive his youth and rediscover his creativity. Undeterred by the raging epidemic, he gets entangled in a homo-erotic relationship with a 15-year-old boy, Tadzio. At last, he falls a victim to cholera and dies.

Gabriel Garcia Marquez's *Love in the Time of Cholera* (1985) tells how roses bloom again in the life of two aged lovers, Florentino Ariza and Fermina Daza. Love had sprouted in their young

hearts decades ago, but fate separated them until they were reunited in their old age, when cholera was stalking the streets of the city. Running out of time, they rededicate themselves to each other.

Dr. Gaustine, the geriatric psychiatrist of *Time Shelter* (2023), the Man Booker Prize winning novel by the Bulgarian novelist Georgi Gospodinov, builds a "clinic of the past" for his ageing Alzheimer's patients, considering their predilection for happy yesterdays. It is a sort of reminiscence therapy, involving psychosocial intervention, based on the recall of the past.

The insights received from literature will provide new ways of looking at the sunset years and will be instrumental in widening the scope of gerontology and humanising it. Writers with their imaginative reaches and intuitive powers can unravel the subtle and inscrutable facets of human experience. Literary narratives on ageing are non-linear and multi-layered. They contest the biomedical model of ageing that considers ageing as a universal and irreversible process.



MORE ON THE WEB
www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

How the Gulf War is affecting gig workers

Its ripple effects are already singing the lives of daily-wage earners trapped in precarious employment
Anjali Deshpande and Kinshuk Gupta

The book fair crowd

Many come because they take the word 'fair' seriously and 'book' as a loose suggestion
Chanchala Borah

Learn to unlearn

Public opinion is unstable; trying to control it is exhausting
K. Suresh Babu

Process is the punishment

Even minor infractions often result in years of legal proceedings
Kritika Sharma

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Joshua Muiyiwa

What is happening here?" said one friend to another (unsurprisingly) during a moment of complete silence in the contemporary dance work being performed on stage. We were in the audience at the 7th edition of the Prakriti Excellence in Contemporary Dance Awards (PECDA), a biennial event that provides financial support, mentorship, and performance and networking opportunities through an open competition for contemporary dance practitioners.

This unfiltered audience member at the Bangalore International Centre auditorium wasn't entirely to blame for their baffled query. The more one watches such live performances, the easier it is to understand abstract work.

India's contemporary dance landscape is perennially in a dicey situation – lack of consistent funding, dwindling grants for creation and research, no institutional support (other than education and training), and hardly any critical writing around it. In this fragile ecosystem, being an opportunity that shows up consistently has been PECDA's greatest win. Over the past 14 years and seven editions, it has stamped itself as the only publicly-available Rosetta Stone to understand the tangential explorations of our nation's contemporary dance choreographers. It has also turned into an occasion to spend a weekend watching performances, attending workshops, and talking with dancers from all over India.

Gateway to the world

The runway of opportunities provided by PECDA begins with its jury, a mix of national and international stakeholders. This year

BODIES IN MOTION

At a time when institutionally backed showcase platforms are disappearing, PECDA is helping keep contemporary dance in India alive



Winning boost

The PECDA winner receives ₹5 lakh to transform their excerpt into a full-length work, and a mentorship with choreographer Saido Lehlouh at an international residency in France. Assistance is provided for the work to go on tour and a showcase guaranteed at the next edition of the awards.



Some of the performances at the 7th edition of the Prakriti Excellence in Contemporary Dance Awards in Bengaluru.



Feeling of community

PECDA's commitment to showing up has recharged the contemporary dance landscape. It has helped previous winners such as Manipur-based choreographer Surjit Nongmeikapam tour their work internationally, as well as nudged Delhi-based Aseng Borang to continue with her contemporary dance practice (as a young choreographer, her PECDA win boosted her confidence to create alongside established artists). It has also contributed to a feeling of community among the country's contemporary dance practitioners and stakeholders, while steadily growing an inquisitive audience.

saw Saido Lehlouh, co-director of the Centre Chorégraphique National de Rennes et de Bretagne in France return, along with other key names from countries such as Australia, the U.K. and Thailand.

This committee was tasked with paring down the written proposals of 52 choreographers – the highest number of applicants till date – to 12 practitioners. The semi-finalists

presented 10-minute excerpts of their dance works over two sessions, and then five finalists received individual sessions of feedback from the jury, had a day of mentoring with senior choreographers, and got rehearsal time to change up any technical factors of their presentations.

Physical intensity

Huddled in anticipatory darkness, we witnessed the works of the five finalists. While thematically, these choreographers took different paths, there seemed to be a marked return to playing with diverse dance vocabulary to polish a language of their own.

On a barely-lit stage, Pandurang Sagbhor slid and slithered across the stage in his work *Body Oddy*, his movement vocabulary powered by the sensuousness of Voguing (a dance form created by LGBTQ+ communities in Harlem that mimicked the poses of *Vogue* models, Egyptian hieroglyphics and acrobatic acts) and punctuated with the restrained

yet frenetic movements that underline contemporary dance. His choreographic choice speaks to the dissonances in his experiences of gender and sexuality, domestic violence and societal constraints.

This thread was further tugged at in Deep Das' *Down To Earth*. One could spot a whisper of Chau and Odissi that echoed the ludic play between Radha and Krishna. In moments of the body whirling, its movement seemed sourced from street-style dances – but here, it was rephrased and refreshed.

Abrar Saqib's *Saturn Is My Spine* and Harini Meraki's *Tit For Tat* were the most cinematic. Saqib's work transported us into the red-glow of a cave haunted with a primal, guttural chorus of voices. It was like we had come upon a warrior's ritual – a prayer that interceded with the gods for strength and scaffolding against doom. Meraki's choreography channelled an arachnid-like, female creature masked with a banana leaf taken over in a spiritual trance. Saqib and Meraki mirrored each other in that they were contemporary re-stagings of spiritual rituals.

Finally, Purnendra Kumar Meshram's *Where It All Began* was a return to another trope of contemporary dance: restraint. Along a slash of light across an otherwise dark stage, Meshram's body crumpled and collapsed into itself. It was meditative, restricting itself to a linear axis that contributed to this dance work feeling grounded.

A visceral reminder

Live dance performances may not have the slick, edited feel of 90-second viral Reel dances.

But they are most rewarding because contemporary dance speaks to the unquenchable humanness to explore and experiment.

Here, the material is the body – something each one of us has. Perhaps, the way to watch it is to look out for these hints of history being retold and reformed.

So, 'what is happening here'? A lot. It isn't simply enough to want to be entertained, but to leave wondering: what burdens and joys do different bodies carry? Being an audience to contemporary dance means to seek and search; it is to allow yourself to be moved.

The writer and poet is based in Bengaluru.



Creating a living memorial

How floral installations from the 2025 Bondi Beach massacre site will transform a place of grief into an archive of memory

Neeta Lal

As images of fresh battlefields dominate global headlines, societies everywhere are once again confronting a familiar question: how should grief be remembered after violence subsides? Long after wars and attacks fade from the news cycle, memorials – quiet gardens, walls of names, scattered flowers – often become the places where loss is processed and history is held.

In Sydney, one artist is transforming that instinct to mourn into something enduring.

When the first truckloads arrived at a warehouse on the outskirts of the city, the air was thick with the sweet, cloying scent of flowers wilting under the late-summer heat. Bouquets had been stacked in dense, damp piles – tributes left at Bondi Beach after Australia's deadliest mass shooting in nearly three decades on December 14, 2025.

Now the warehouse feels different. Windows are cracked open. Industrial fans hum. Long tables stretch wall to wall, covered not in chaos but in careful order. Petals lie flattened between sheets of tissue paper. Leaves are arranged by shade. Seeds rest in labelled trays. Grief has been reorganised into discipline.

This is where Melbourne-based Jewish artist and Artistic Director at Goldstone Gallery, Nina Sanadze, 49, is building a living memorial to the victims of the Bondi Beach massacre. Known for working with materials salvaged from sites of trauma, Sanadze says she has long collected newspaper clippings documenting synagogue vandalism, arson attacks and threats. She imagines embedding those clippings alongside the preserved Bondi flowers, creating parchment-like walls where history and grief collapse into one another. "This



isn't a one-off," she says. "It's part of something larger."

The Bondi memorial will be unveiled at the Sydney Jewish Museum when it opens to public following a major redevelopment in 2027.

Refusing erasure

Spontaneous memorials are fragile by nature. They bloom quickly – flowers, candles, handwritten notes – and then, just as swiftly, they are dismantled. The tributes are disposed of discreetly. The public ritual ends.

Sanadze could not bear the thought of that happening at Bondi. More than three tonnes of bouquets – sunflowers, roses, orchids, wattles, bougainvillea – had been left along the shoreline. Where authorities saw a logistical problem,

Sanadze saw art. Working alongside curator Shannon Biederman and the team at the Sydney Jewish Museum, she proposed an alternative: collect everything. Preserve it. Transform it. Allow the memorial to evolve rather than disappear.

"Nothing is thrown away," she insists. "Not even the seeds." Even weeks after the site was formally closed, fresh bouquets continued to appear at Bondi. Sanadze returned repeatedly to retrieve them.

Seeds saved, pollen extracted

The operation was vast. Trucks ferried the flowers from the beach to the warehouse in large plastic bags. Inside the warehouse, over 100 volunteers are busy with preservation work. Some are artists. Others retirees, students and professionals taking time off work.



(Clockwise from left) Artist Nina Sanadze who is working on the Bondi Beach memorial project; a volunteer sorting flowers; and Sydney Jewish Museum, where the floral tributes will be displayed. (COURTESY NINA SANADZE)



Many come from Sydney's Jewish community, still reeling from the attack that took place during a celebration of the Jewish holiday of Hanukkah, attended by around 1,000 people. Two gunmen killed 15

people, including three women and a child. A trial against the sole surviving assailant began last month.

The process of preserving the floral tributes is meticulous. Petals are gently removed, pressed and ironed flat between tissue paper to halt decay. Pollen is extracted and processed into pigment for future paintings. Leaves that fall to the floor are gathered and boxed with the same reverence as intact blossoms. Seeds are dried, catalogued and saved for replanting.

Professional florists are brought in to identify species. Everything is labelled and archived: colour, type, condition, origin, if known. The floor is lined with trays of gumnuts, zigzag wattles, Singapore orchids. Some flowers retain their brilliance when dried; others darken to brittle

browns, their forms collapsing into fragile silhouettes.

Volunteers in vigil

For many volunteers, the repetitive labour is grounding. "I wanted to do something useful," says Alana Gomez, one of the volunteers. "I couldn't think of anything more beautiful than keeping the flowers and turning them into something that helps us remember."

Sanadze speaks openly about the visceral anger she felt in the immediate aftermath of the massacre. Like many, she was overwhelmed – by sorrow, by outrage. Working with flowers changed that. "I can't afford to fall apart," she says. "This work keeps me moving. This is way beyond an art project."

Imagining 2027

The preservation phase is nearing completion. Soon, thousands upon thousands of pressed petals, dried leaves and catalogued seeds will be boxed and stored until the Sydney Jewish Museum reopens next year.

What the final memorial will look like remains a mystery though. "I envision multiple rooms where the work unfolds slowly, where visitors move through layers of material and meaning," says Sanadze. Paintings made from pigments extracted from petals. Installations incorporating the handwritten messages left by mourners. An indoor garden grown from salvaged seeds, alive and breathing within the museum walls. Sanadze believes flowers communicate in a way politics cannot. "Flowers go beyond words," she says. "They remind us – quietly, insistently – that this is not OK. There's nothing like a garden to give us hope for the future."

The writer is a senior journalist and editor exploring the intersections of art, culture, gastronomy and travel in South Asia and beyond.